me consolation too, in the Bhagavad Gita's dictum that one did what was one's *dharma* to do, regardless of the consequences.)

Hinduism does not see the world in terms of absolutes. Blacks and whites are largely absent from its ethos. It sees competing notions of good and evil, duty and betrayal, everywhere, and seeks wisdom in finding the right approach suited for each specific circumstance. Vivekananda used to tell a parable of the frog in the well: 'I am a Hindu. I am sitting in my own little well and thinking that the whole world is my little well. The Christians sit in their little well and think the whole world is their well. The Muslims sit in their little well and think that is the whole world.' To Vivekananda, the world was one where each frog had much to learn from the others, if he would only look beyond his well.

Hinduism is not a totalising belief system; it offers a way of coping with the complexity of the world. It acknowledges that the truth is plural, that there is no one correct answer to the big questions of creation, or of the meaning of life. In its reverence for sages and rishis, it admits that knowledge may come from an exchange between two or more views, neither of which necessarily possesses a monopoly on the truth. The greatest truth, to the Hindu, is that which accepts the existence of other truths.

Hinduism sees life as an evolving dynamic, not a contest that can ever be settled once and for all. It is open to negotiation on ways of being and believing; it permits negotiation even with God. It offers rites and rituals, but leaves it up to each individual to choose which ones he wishes to adhere to. Each Hindu must find his own truth. Each individual achieves his own salvation and self-fulfilment.

At the same time Hinduism is also anchored in the real world. A superficial view of Hinduism sees its other-worldly 'timelessness'. But in fact the religion is anchored not in a world-denying spirituality, as Raimon Panikkar points out; in his words, it is not the timeless, but the 'time-full', which wins Vedic approbation. Time is depicted in hymns in the *Atharva Veda* as perpetually replenishing itself from a full vessel which, in spite of all efforts, can never be emptied. Since time transcends time, it is without beginning or end, without limit; and in that sense it is like God. 'Time am I, world-destroying,' says Krishna in the Bhagavad